

INNOCENCE IN SHACKLES

Even as jails in Bihar and Jharkhand try to provide children of inmates some normalcy, juvenile offenders are still ill-treated

Photographs by KISHORE KUMAR KUMAR



CAGED: Mina with daughter Juli in Patna (right); a class in Beur jail (above)



53 jails in Bihar house 40, 882 prisoners, including 1,340 women inmates

253 children under the age of six are in the jails of Bihar with imprisoned parents

141 children live in Jharkhand's jails along with either one of their parents

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

It's been three months since four-year-old Sonu has seen his favourite neighbourhood puppy. It is not the only part of his life that he finds difficult. He can no longer go on a bicycle ride to nearby market with his father, misses the courtyard he played in, his friends, and, most of all, the television.

Life has not been the same for this toddler since August when he had to accompany his mother Tunija Pravin, to a new address: Beur jail in Patna. Every time her son asks why she is in prison, Pravin, an undertrial facing ab-

duction charges, has always told a different lie. It makes Pravin both sad and angry as Sonu's father is now absconding and does not have to answer the child's questions.

Sonu may still be fortunate because he has some fond memories that breed hope. For some others of his age lodged in Beur, the periphery of the prison is the only world they know.

They have never seen the outside world, be it an elephant or a tractor. All that 21 children here have by way of toys are a few dusty teddy bears and some broken trucks. Alternative entertainment can be found in a malfunctioning television that airs only Doordarshan. For 253 children in Bihar, home is prison. They are forced to live in captivity while their parents serve their sentences because they have been refused shelter everywhere else. Their only option is to live in jail with either one or both parents. In some cases, children were even born inside the prison.

Rules allow those below six years of age to live in their parents' cells, prison officials accept that often some stay on until they are much older because they have nowhere else to go. At the moment Bihar's jails have 1,340 women